Gwalior and Baroda were said to belong to the same race. A three-volume history of the 'Kshatriya Maratha Samaj' by Keshavrao Bapu Deshmukh had also drawn a similar inference, Gaikwad says.

A senior BJP legislator says the party and the ruling coalition are in a quandary over the demand. The previous Maratha morchas, which were seen to have the NCP's support, had led to a section of the OBCs coalescing behind the BJP, and the party cannot risk antagonising them by including the Marathas in this category. However, the deputy CM Ajit Pawar-led NCP faction has to cater to its core constituency of the Marathas. There is a risk that like in 2016, the protests could acquire larger hues.



"THERE IS NO CASTE CALLED THE MARATHAS...KUNBIS WERE MARGINAL, RAIN-FED FARMERS; THOSE AMONG THEM WHO TOOK TO A MARTIAL WAY OF LIFE AFTER COMPLETING THEIR FARMING DUTIES WERE CALLED MARATHAS"

PRAVIN GAIKWAD Head, Sambhaji Brigade

"The fresh agitations are a result of the government launching recruitments for vacant posts," says the legisator. "Maratha youngsters feel that a quota will improve their chances of making it into government employment."

The backwards, though, resent the Maratha demand to be categorised as OBCs. They are a diverse mix of around 400 classes and castes across the religious divide (43.7 per cent are Hindus and 8.4 per cent non-Hindus). The OBCs, who compete with Marathas for control of local power structures, think that including the numerically significant Marathas in the category will deprive them of quota benefits, including political reservations. Earlier, three commissions had rejected the demand of the Marathas to be classified as backwards as had the National Commission for Backward Classes in 2000. "The government will regret any such decision (to categorise the Marathas and Kunbis as one)," warns Vishwanath Patil of the Kunbi Sena, an association of the Kunbis, while threatening a protest.

Shabbir Ahmed Ansari, the founder-president of the All India Muslim OBC Organisation, and one of the veterans of the OBC movement, says the Maratha groups resented the rise of the other backwards and hence wanted to get into the category. "The Constitution says that reservations have been granted based on educational and social backwardness..., (but) the Marathas hold political power. The poor from the community can get quotas through the EWS category," he says. The Marathas now want to get into the OBC category to enjoy these benefits, he charges, while warning of protests if these demands were heeded.

The Marathas are traditionally seen as the ruling class and account for a majority of the state's chief ministers and legislators. They have a strong grip on the levers of power. However, a significant number of Marathas remain outside these exalted circles of power.

Maharashtra's arid dust bowl of Marathwada is one of the epicentres of the Maratha quota agitation. Political analysts link these protests to the growing agrarian distress coupled with fragmentation of land and lack of remunerative pricing for agricultural produce, which makes farming unviable. They note that the political class has managed to wrongly market reservations as a 'garibi hatao' programme.

OBC groups have retaliated with counter-protests. Babanrao Taywade of the Rashtriya OBC Mahasangh wants the Union government to amend the law and the Constitution to do away with any cap on quotas to ensure that the Marathas get reservations.

Shravan Deore, founder-president of the OBC Rajkiya Aghadi, questions how the government could "succumb to the protests by a handful of people" and says that the apex court's 2021 judgment striking down the Maratha quota had effectively granted a sense of closure to the demand. He warns of reprisals by the OBCs in the 2024 election if the Marathas are clubbed with them.

Congress leader and leader of the Opposition Vijay Wadettiwar, also an OBC leader, has said that if the Marathas are to be included in the OBC category, the reservations for the other backwards must be increased from the present 27 per cent (19 per cent for OBCs and 11 per cent for the Vimukta Jatis and Nomadic Tribes) so that the OBCs are not deprived.

The Maratha quota demand has opened a veritable Pandora's box with more such demands coming forth from other social groups. For instance, the Dhangar (shepherd) community, which includes both pastoralists and settled farmers, wants to be included in the scheduled tribes (ST) category, something that the tribals resist.

Despite the caste cauldron being on the boil over quota demands, there is no scientific measurement of caste numbers, leading to exaggerated claims and demands. For instance, while the OBCs are seen to be leading at over 52 per cent, a commission under former chief secretary J.K. Banthia had assessed their population at 37 per cent. The Marathas, too, may be around 12 to 16 per cent, if you exclude the Kunbis. The last caste-based census had taken place in 1931 in British India. The decennial census exercise collects data only for scheduled castes and STs.

In 2021, the Maharashtra State Commission for Backward Classes (MSCBC) had submitted a proposal of around Rs 435 crore to the state government for a caste census. Sadly, it has yet to see the light of day. ■